

The 5-Pile Sorting System

Module 2 — Reference Card (Print and Post)

Print this page and tape it to the wall in whatever room you're working in. Every item goes into one of these five piles. One item, one decision, one pile.

1. KEEP

What goes here: Items moving to the next chapter.

Criteria: Loved, essential, or used at least once in the past year.

Ask yourself: Will this fit in the new space? Do I use it? Does it bring genuine joy?

2. DONATE

What goes here: Items someone else can enjoy.

Criteria: Clean, functional, in decent condition.

Tip: Schedule a charity pickup (Goodwill, Salvation Army). Get a tax receipt for items over \$250.

3. SELL

What goes here: Items with real monetary value (\$50+).

Criteria: Antiques, quality furniture, tools, collectibles, jewelry.

Tip: Don't sell a \$5 lamp. Your time is worth more. Consider an estate sale company for large volumes.

4. TOSS

What goes here: Items that are done.

Criteria: Broken, expired, stained, damaged, missing pieces, outdated.

Tip: Don't feel guilty. A broken toaster from 2003 is not a keepsake.

5. NOT SURE YET

What goes here: Anything that causes hesitation, disagreement, or emotion.

Criteria: If anyone says "I'm not ready to decide" — it goes here. No judgment.

Come back in 2-4 weeks. Most families find 70% of this pile becomes Donate or Toss once the emotional intensity fades.

RYAN'S TIP: The Not Sure Yet pile is the most important pile in this system. It's not about avoiding decisions — it's about making them at the right time. I've watched families blow up because someone threw away something the senior wasn't ready to part with. This pile prevents that. Use it freely. It costs nothing.

THE KEY RULE: Touch each item once. Make a decision (even if it's Not Sure Yet) and place it in its pile. Don't put it back where it was. Progress means items leave their current location.

Upload your completed sort results to your SeniorSafe vault at app.seniorsafeapp.com so your family can see progress.
